

# Meta Horizon Creator Competition: Game Design

## Player Journey Map

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**Game Title:** Eight Counts to Midnight

**Journey Focus:** First 15 minutes of onboarding, from Day 1 solo dance to Day 2 first partner dance.

## First 15 Minutes Flowchart

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flowchart TD
    A["0:00 - Arrival<br/>Ruined Grand Ballroom, silent music, Alistair frozen in stone"] --> B["0:30 - Touch the statue<br/>A faint Bachata count starts under the floor"]
    B --> C["1:00 - Guided solo phrase<br/>Drag Basic Side-Step into Bar A"]
    C --> D["2:00 - Complete the 8-count<br/>Basic Side-Step + Basic Side-Step + Head Accent"]
    D --> E["3:00 - Beat 8 payoff<br/>Head Accent lands, stone cracks across Alistair"]
    E --> F["4:00 - Dawn growth<br/>Ballroom floor clears, Beginner Confidence I unlocks"]
    F --> G["6:00 - Alistair wakes<br/>He explains that sustained dance can break the curse"]
    G --> H["8:00 - Day 2 preparation<br/>Choose Train Technique + Rehearse Cards"]
    H --> I["10:00 - First partner setup<br/>Close Invitation appears as Alistair's lead"]
    I --> J["12:00 - Player responds<br/>Foil Basic Step -> Step Into Close -> Close Sway"]
    J --> K["14:00 - Perfect Connection<br/>Camera tightens as Alistair's hand settles at her waist"]
    K --> L["15:00 - Return hook / SESSION 1 ENDS<br/>Day 2 dawn screen. Mirror Hall preview: train for advanced leads tomorrow"]
```

**Where the first session ends:** A natural stop lands at the Day 2 dawn screen (~15:00). The player has completed one full loop (solo awakening, first partner dance, first growth payoff) and is handed a clear reason to return. A shorter 5-10 minute session can end one beat earlier, at the Day 1 dawn growth (~4:00), which also closes a complete loop. Both endpoints leave the player on a reward and a forward hook, never mid-phrase.

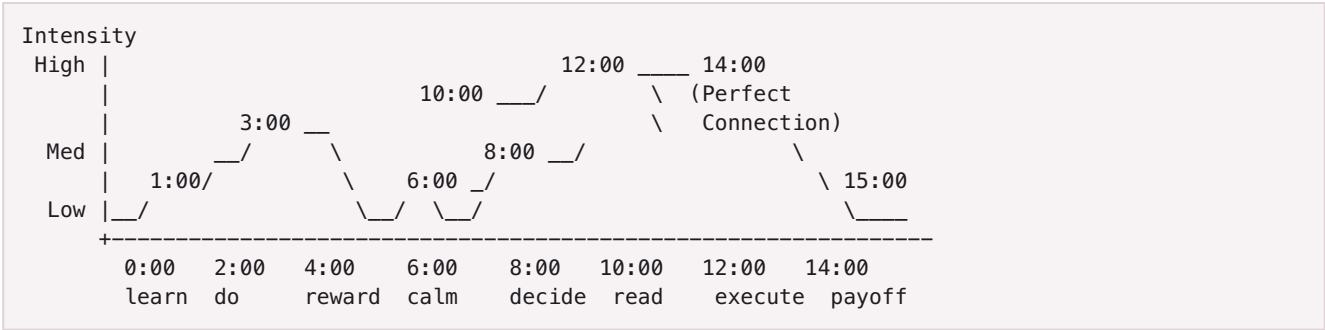
## Journey Table

| Stage                       | First 30 sec                                                  | ~1-3 min                                                                             | ~3-8 min                                                                   | ~8-15 min                                                                           |
|-----------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| What the player sees & does | Enter the ruined Grand Ballroom. Alistair is frozen in stone. | Touch his hand. Complete a guided solo 8-count with Basic Side-Step and Head Accent. | Beat 8 cracks the stone. Dawn clears part of the Ballroom. Alistair wakes. | Train Technique, rehearse cards, then answer Close Invitation with Step Into Close. |

| Stage           | First 30 sec               | ~1-3 min                                                      | ~3-8 min                                               | ~8-15 min                                                                              |
|-----------------|----------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Decision points | Tap the statue hand.       | Place guided cards into Bar A / Bar B and attach Head Accent. | Accept the first growth reward: Beginner Confidence I. | Spend 2 Day Actions: Train Technique and Rehearse Cards into Foil Basic Step.          |
| Challenge       | Curiosity and orientation. | Guided timing: learn that 8 Beats make one phrase.            | See cause and effect: good timing changes the curse.   | Enter Close before Beat 5 to earn Perfect Connection.                                  |
| Emotional beat  | Gothic curiosity.          | Vulnerability: she dances alone while the manor watches.      | Wonder: her dance mattered.                            | Trust: the first partner dance turns Alistair into someone she must learn to read.     |
| Return hook     | Who is the statue?         | Finish the first phrase.                                      | Alistair is awake and Day 2 is promised.               | Mirror Hall points to the next goal: train for smoother, closer, more advanced dances. |

# Difficulty & Intensity Curve

The first 15 minutes follow a guided sawtooth: each new demand is taught, executed, then rewarded with a calm beat before the next, harder ask. Challenge never spikes without a prior teaching moment.



| Beat                     | Time      | Challenge    | Why the curve moves here                                                |
|--------------------------|-----------|--------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Arrival                  | 0:00      | Minimal      | Pure orientation. No fail state.                                        |
| Guided solo phrase       | 1:00-2:00 | Low (guided) | Teaches the 8-beat rule with rails on. Cards are placed for the player. |
| Beat 8 payoff            | 3:00      | Reward spike | Emotional high, not a skill test. Confirms cause and effect.            |
| Dawn + Alistair wakes    | 4:00-6:00 | Low (calm)   | Narrative breather. Banks the first reward before new demands.          |
| Day 2 preparation        | 8:00      | Medium       | First real decision: spend 2 Day Actions with tradeoffs.                |
| Close Invitation appears | 10:00     | Medium-high  | First genuine challenge: read the lead and plan a stance change.        |

| Beat               | Time  | Challenge    | Why the curve moves here                                        |
|--------------------|-------|--------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|
| Player responds    | 12:00 | High         | First unaided execution under the Beat-5 constraint.            |
| Perfect Connection | 14:00 | Reward spike | Skill payoff. The hardest ask resolves into the biggest moment. |
| Return hook        | 15:00 | Low (calm)   | Resolution plus a forward pull toward tomorrow's training.      |

The principle: **teach on a low beat, test on a rising beat, reward on a spike, then rest.** No mechanic is tested before it is taught, and every difficulty spike is immediately followed by a payoff and a calm beat.

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## Key Onboarding Promise

The first 15 minutes should make one idea clear:

Preparation changes the dance. The dance changes the manor.

Day 1 proves that dance has supernatural power. Day 2 proves that preparation creates better connection.

Mortal outsider -> first solo rhythm -> stone cracks -> vampire wakes -> first partner connection -> tomorrow's training goal